Shadows of the Rocky Mountains



PEOPLE & PLACES OF THE COMMONWEALTH

FALL 2026

Shadows of the Rocky Mountains

PEOPLE & PLACES OF THE COMMONWEALTH

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in sunny Denver

visit us at https://shadows.institute

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First Edition - 2026

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This fourth issue marks the end of our first full annual publishing cycle! I've already waxed poetic about seeing projects continue into the future, so I won't bore you with a whole page on it again. Needless to say, thank you to all the readers and writers of this periodical for your precious time, money, and attention over the last year. Shadows of the Rocky Mountains would be nothing without you.

So with the grinding crunch of a manual transmission worked by someone who doesn't drive stick, let's change gears. You might notice a new piece type in the publication this go around, an Op-Ed! That's right, we're in the throws of yet another election cycle here in the Commonwealth. What, you think we pushed The Feds across the Mississippi for less democracy!? Needless to say, if you've had your head in the sand, I hope you will take this as a sign to pull up and get a little more involved in things. Freedom is a constant struggle, all politics are local, and democracy does not begin or end at the ballot box. While we can always do more, voting is at least the least we can do.

In solidarity,
Corvus van Roodland



The following Letter To the Editor contains only the views of the signed individual and does not represent the views of the editorial board - CvR

Eliminating the Stigma of Demon Possession

Father L'Azar and his Catholic cronies will have you believe we live in some plague-demon time of non-consensual possession, but I'll tell you this: ain't nobody getting between me and my demon, Devil's Food Cake. Chocolaty rich and sweet to boot, I could just live in him, but lucky-ducky, he lives in me. He bakes in me. He aches in me. Hell, he gives me reason to be, just actually be, and most importantly, to not be me.

You think I like running this ship? Living in this body? The doomscroll, the gluten-free pizza, the undiagnosable rash? No, ma'am. No thanks. Bye!

Sure, there are times when I regain "control", times like now, where I can scribble with a pen and stand up for him, but you know what? I miss him already. I miss his hands in my hands. His feet in my feet. And then watching those hands take the steering wheel and those feet put pedal to the metal. Oh, baby, I'm getting hot just thinking about it. Vroom vroom! He can drive this car off a cliff and I would be ecstatic.

Because what L'Azar calls possession, I call release. What he calls demon, I call freedom. Freedom to let go. Are you hearing me? Let someone else decide. Let them operate. Let them walk you into a bank and rob it. Let them sky dive you into a volcano and blow it all to hell.

Those born-again coconuts, nodding and frowning in their pews while L'Azar talks about Satan's spawn and Beezelbub's babies. If they could only see what DFCs shown me. That we're all possessed by something: false idols, holy ghosts, yodeling yokai, rogue AI. We all get swept up at some point - that don't mean you get to exorcise me! That don't mean you get to reach inside my body and pull out my Devil's Food Cake, or anyone's cake for that matter!

And that's why I'm saying this October 2057, make the vote to keep those in control controlling those who want to be controlled, controlled. Vote Yes on Prop 666!



Thank you,

Little Debbie - Local Prairie Dog Taxidermist

Magical Covens and Communes of Denver

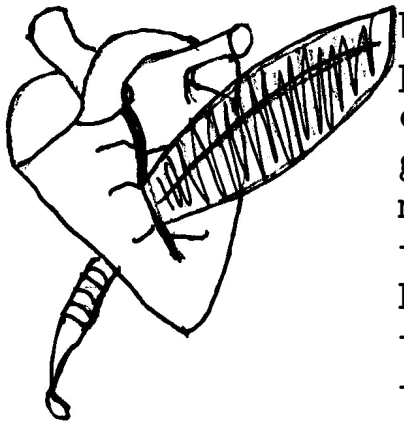
While the pop culture image is often that of a lone witch in a wooded cabin or an isolated wizard in a distant tower, magical practitioners of the Commonwealth are often drawn together from varied covens into localized communes of practice. The city of Denver has five such communes spread across its geography. In each, there is a majority coven that sets the overall culture without infringing the non-dominant sects, as all practitioners in the city understand the strength of diversity.

Central Commune - Coven of Stitch & Herb



It is no surprise that the commune at the center of the City primarily practices magics of charm and connection. Weaving fates together and brewing teas to manage relationships (be that stitching nervous lovers together or ripping out the seams between toxic couples), one can always expect a warm welcome and cozy hospitality from practitioners of this coven. At least as long as you stay on the proper side of the shifting weft and warp of etiquette that underpins all their interactions.

Northwest Commune - Coven of Ink & Blood



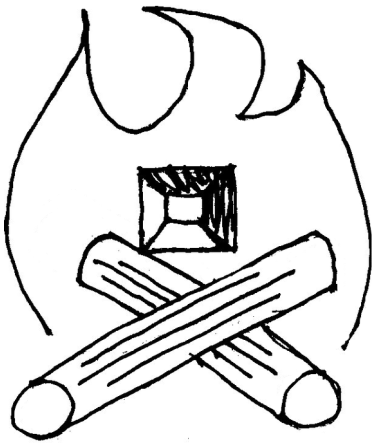
Would a rose by any other name not still draw blood? Masters of words and emotions, practitioners of this coven wield one of the oldest magics: naming. Be wary of the name they give you, for it often hides a truth. And be even more on guard about sharing yours with them, lest they cast a spell to steal it and bind you. But honestly that's only a problem if you really piss them off, like mocking their slash fic. Usually they're too distracted writing love sonnets to each other to care.

Northeast Commune - Coven of Prong & Thorn



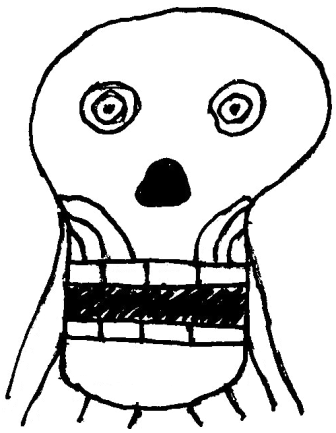
Colloquially known as druids, these practitioners follow the natural cycles of life and death amongst the kingdoms of animal, vegetable, and fungi. They often walk barefoot, saying it connects them better to the mycelial networks buried in the earth. They can harness the skulls of animals to channel transformation spells. Many of them are master gardeners, with decadent heirloom tomato varieties or strange and exotic pepper strands. They are also the only people who still grow ditch weed. The lab grown stuff jinxes their transformation rituals, many druids have confided in me.

Southwest Commune -- Coven of Ash & Amber



In fire there is a cleansing power, one capable of transforming matter from one form into another. In flames, the children of the forest are reborn, poking gently out of the ash. Likewise, these same forests hide amber and quartz and bauxite. Rocks and gems and minerals each possessing useful quantities and unique traits. Practitioners of this coven are fond of materials and processes, as well as lengthy alchemical processes of transformation. Think straw into gold or grain into beer.

Southeast Commune -- Coven of Sweat & Sinew



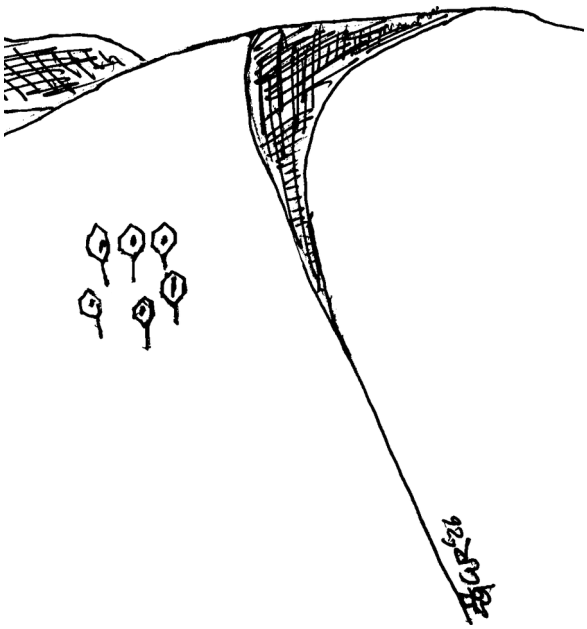
Blunt, brute force twists and grinds and snaps against the immovable object of the universe. Bitter glands pumping the fluids of life back and forth, in and out. The clock is ticking, and the practitioners aim to make the most of it. Optimized reagents yield perfect growth curves. Anything to move the needle 1 millimeter past where it was last time. And if they can't do it with their own life or body? Then they will craft clay or meat in their own image and see if the clone is up to the task.

Siren of the Sand Dunes - Great Sand Dunes

Art and Entry By: 蒲松龄 (Pu SongLing)

Shamans seek secret sands
Scattered in shifting slopes
Somewhere unseen the Siren stands
Somewhere she still hopes

She sings a sonorous song they say
Soft as shimmering sands
"Stay still, sweet seekers, so no wrong
Will fall upon your hands"



But sinking steps slip and slide
Stumble spin and swat
Splash into the silicon tide
Spitting swirling hot

Sand submerged shamans swim
Scrambled searching strokes
Suddenly something sucks them in
"Surrender or you'll choke"

Sixty seeds of sixty suns
Sprouted sixty stalks
Sprawling, some bear secret spells
Scattered in sand and rocks

The Siren secures her star-born stash
As songs silence the screaming
Of sand sunk shamans buried and smashed
Struggling stuck yet breathing

But should some steal successfully
A spell from her sorcerous sands
Seldom would speak of their destiny
For that was always the Siren's plan

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The Engulfer - Alpine

(Armadillidium Immanis)

ENTRY By: Dr. Irene Supod

Many people believe that the emergence of *Armadillidium immanis*, better known colloquially as The Engulfer, is a new phenomenon, brought about by these end times we find ourselves in. But upon further inspection, research reveals that this creature may have been with us for longer than we might expect.

The following are excerpts from my vast research, comprising the most compelling suspected cases of Armadillidium immanis.

Excerpt from a found journal of a "Tie Hack," 1881:

May 6, 1881

Made camp near Marshall Pass to begin clearcutting. Camp rations portioned.

May 7, 1881

Felling has begun. Odd sink holes have been found around the forest, unclear of origin.

May 8, 1881

Matthew has not returned to camp, presumed abandoned. Felling continues.

May 10, 1881

More crew disappearing near the sink hole sites. Deep rumbling heard at night, as if a mining drill were running beneath us.

May 14, 1881

I saw a segmented body emerge from the sink holes. Its beastly legs engulfed Thomas. It wrapped its body around him and pulled him under. I fear the others have fallen to this beast. All work has ceased. The camp has been abandoned.

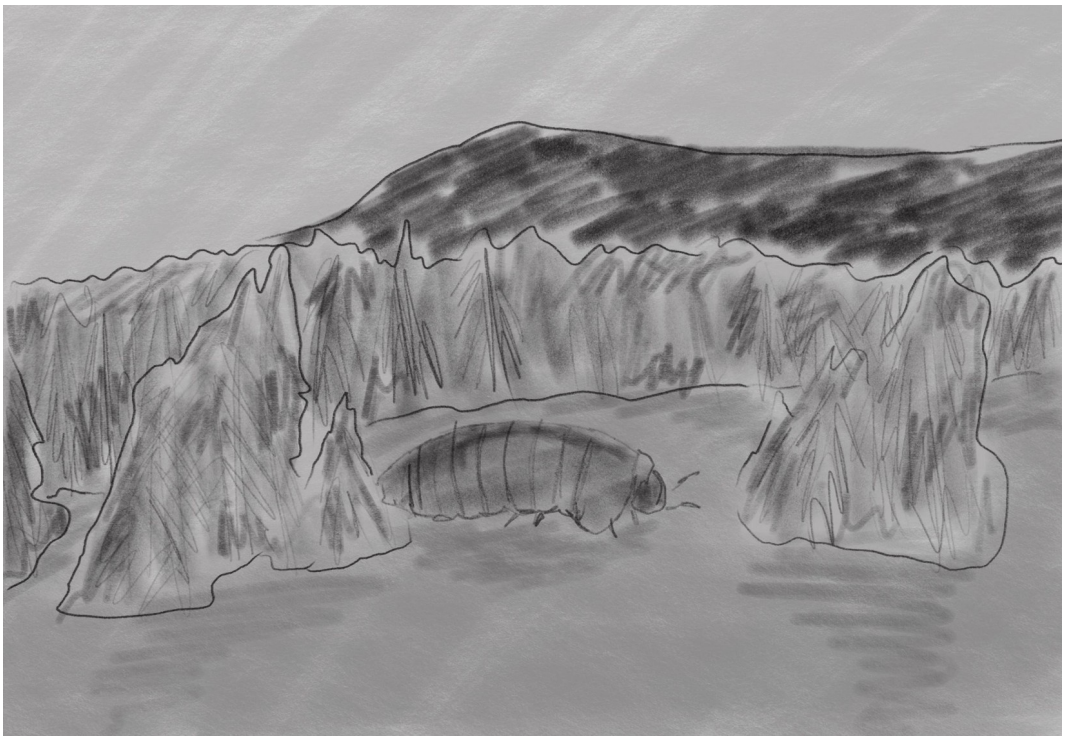
May 15, 1881

The last of the crew is trying to escape. The sink holes continue to appear around us. More of us are being taken before my very eyes.

God help us all.

Considering that this was the last entry, and that this journal was uncovered during deep excavation work, one can only assume that the author befell the same gruesome fate as his crew.

Similarly, in the 1950s, a veteran by the name of Theodore Reskins fled into the woods following the War, hoping to escape his memories. His name may sound familiar, as his biological descriptions and ethologies were later published in the Rocky Mountain Field Guide. He described many iconic creatures of The West and his drawings are still used in guides to this day. However, in reviewing the primary source (his original field journals), I stumbled across this hastily drawn image with no description:



It was sandwiched between several seemingly normal animals, and he wrote nothing about his encounter. It is strange indeed to again see this creature appear in hidden literature.

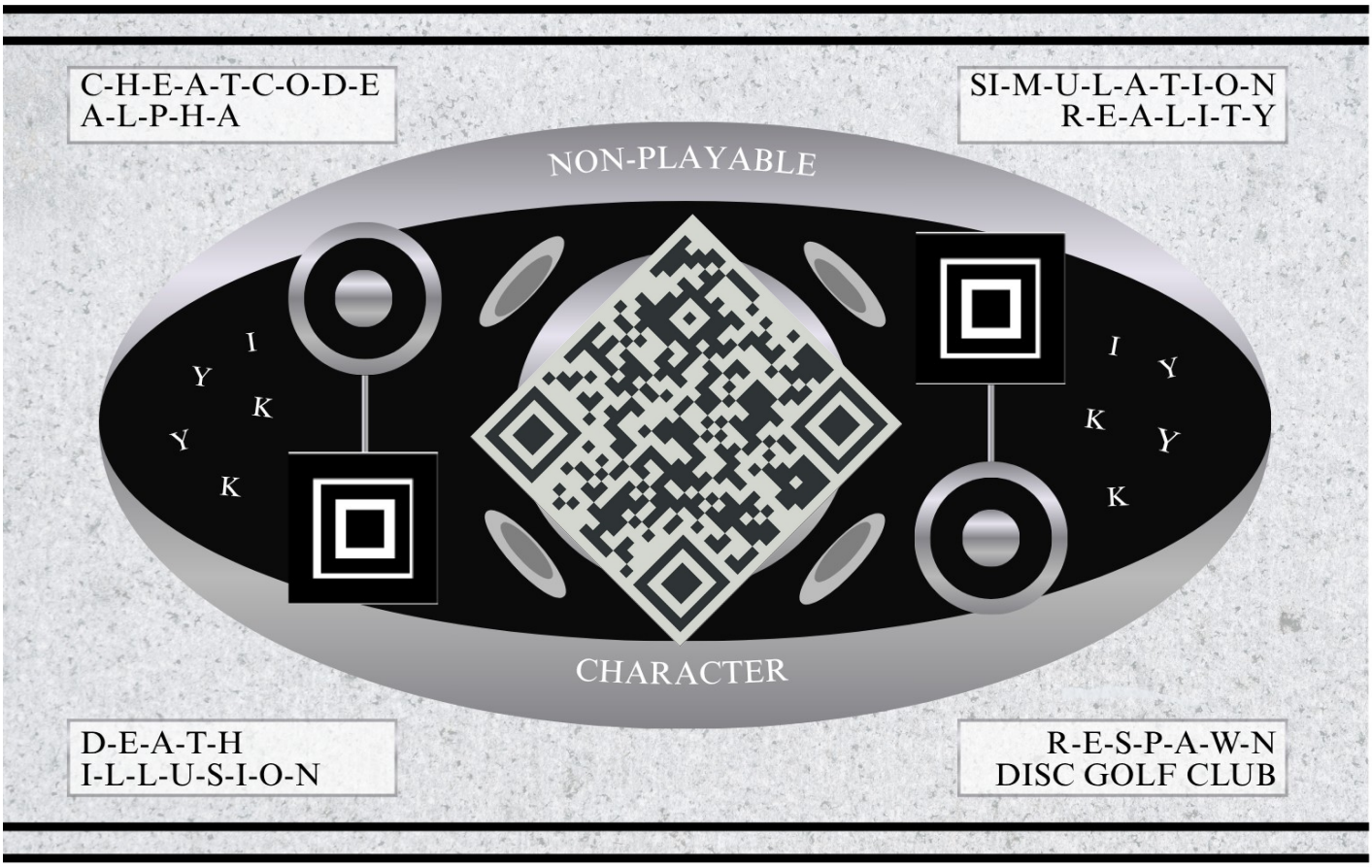
Finally, in 2032, wildlife photographer Mark Latham was trekking in the waning alpine forests following the 2030 Collegiate Peaks wildfires to document the effect on local animals. He took this bizarre picture and submitted it for publication.

Unfortunately, due to the absurd nature of the pictured beast, his submissions were rejected as they were considered a hoax. He published the photo online on many cryptid forums to mixed reception. Ultimately, Mark quietly stepped away from his life of photography and the online forums and faded into obscurity.



Though the evidence is sparse, I do believe each of these encounters points towards *Armadillidium immanis* being a persistent menace rather than an acute threat. However, it does seem that there are more and more reports of this creature emerging from the ground to encapsulate its prey and dive under.

More hikers are going missing in Alpine forests near tunnel sites, and these disappearances seem to drift closer and closer to our fragile civilization.
So please stay safe, dear readers. Don't go in the woods alone. Avoid sink holes and unexplained tunnels. Step carefully lest you fall into the isopodic arms of
The Engulfer.



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Looking down at the peasants on the street

Dwell ancient parasites of the GDP

Plotting and planning to shear the realm's sheep

Amidst the cold halls of power they glide

Gold and paper hide their empty dead eyes

Buying laws that bind from Mayors with pride

They, the Shareholders, whose profit we supply

Now they demand of the peasants anew

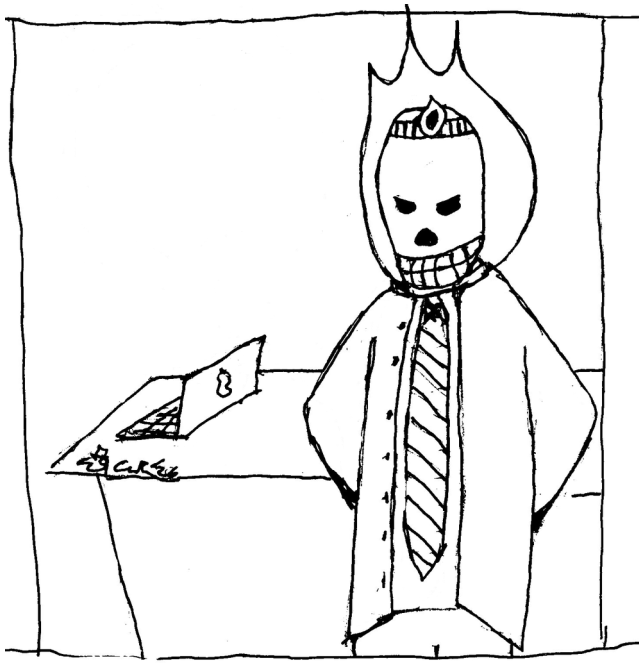
Orders to return to the office spires

More of our time and stress for their value

Lording naked power over their hires

But the Liches have forgotten one thing yet

Peasants possess both ballot and bayonet



Uncle Karl's Reservoir - Alpine

Art and Entry By: 蒲松龄 (Pu SongLing)

Some claim a land is cursed
Only by witches' spells
Others say it's bad deeds
That turn good lands to Hell

But fissures in the earth
That your eyes cannot see
Hide beneath such places
To hex the air you breathe

Uncle Karl's Reservoir
Is such a place I'm told
Its shores have long run dry
And living long run cold

There it's cold that lingers
Even on blistering days
Drawing heated victims
Who never will be saved

It's not the chill that kills
Nor an unlucky streak
But the crawling fog
That drains you in your sleep

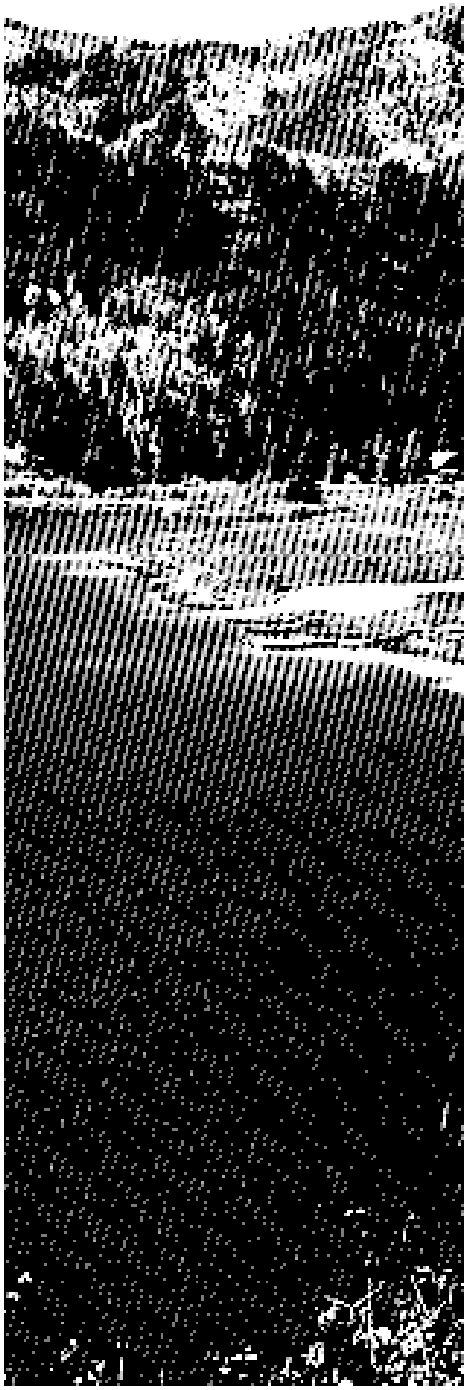
So on your arrival
After a grueling hike
Set down your heavy bags
To enjoy the cool night

Light a little campfire
And pitch a little tent
Roll out your sleeping bag
And turn in since you're spent

Tender as a soft kiss
That sends chills down your spine
The fog will apparate
To take your flesh and mind

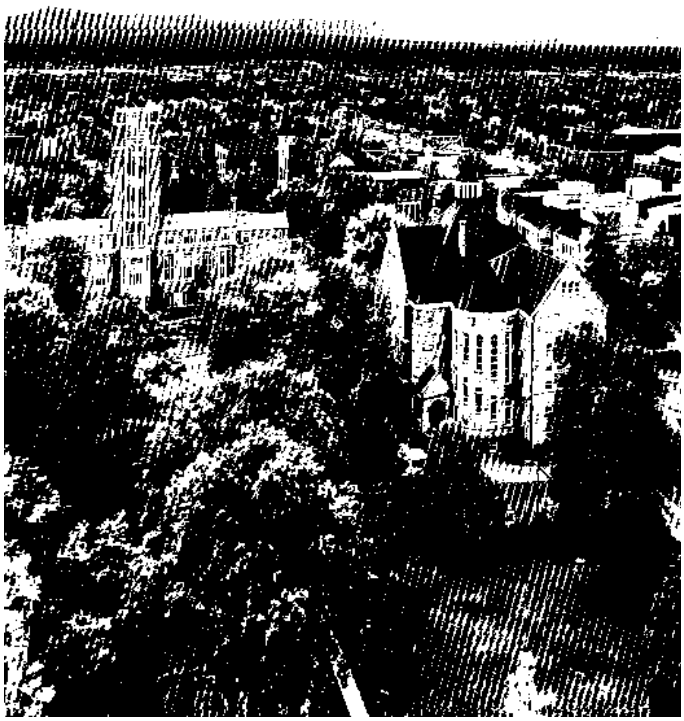
Your joints will all stiffen
Your throat let out a moan
Your skin will wash away
And bones be turned to stone

For on a dry lake bed
Few feel it in the air
But time reveals to all
Which lands hold great despair



Higher Education in the Mile High City

Colfax University



The oldest of Denver's higher education institutions. Founded in 1871 as Colfax Seminary, it was named after then Vice President Schuyler Colfax in an effort to curry favor with him.

Founded on the site of a cabbage field on a hill a half days ride from downtown, it is home to the state of Colorado's first observatory.

For over a century this prestigious university has served as an important mechanism for the city's old money families to use their fortunes to launder their fail sons & daughters into adults with the appearance of intellect and sophistication befitting the scions of such pedigree.

Indeed, up until the 1980s (when the practice fell out of fashion in favor of directly appointing their kids VPs of Regional Sales) 70% of the Departmental Chairs of the university were 3rd cousins or closer with each other.

Queen City College

Queen City College (QCC) is in fact three separate colleges stacked in a trench coat. They all share the same campus and student Union building, so most people tend to just treat the three underlying colleges as the same institution.

One of the colleges specializes in the Liberal Arts, one is closer to a classic Agricultural & Mechanical program, and the last grew out of the Teacher's (or Normal) school.



No one knows which college started with which program though, as they all started offering each other's curriculum in an attempt to draw students. Now no one can even remember the original college's names, as at this point they're all just QCC. The only legacy of the distinct colleges that lives on is the very competitive Red, Green, and Blue intramural teams.

The Grand Umbra of the Shadows

While the average Denverite is generally aware of the previous two campuses, few know of the occluded orrery known as the Grand Umbra of the Shadows.

No one knows exactly when it was founded. Some say it grew out of the Masonic lodges of the early Republic's days, others say it has ties to the Bavarian Illuminati, others still say it was originally started as a secret CIA black site during the Cold War. Most people agree that it doesn't really exist, which is exactly how its faculty want it.

The highest order of lodge in the elusive Shadow's network, rumors of the Institute indicate that it is host to many magical entrance portals that lead inward toward its sprawling maze of classrooms, lounges, archives, cafes, and laboratories. Within its dimly lit halls, cutting edge research is conducted on the veil and the yokai it spawns.

Submissions are open for the next issue!

WINTER 2027

STORIES FROM THE MOUNTAINS

SUBMISSION DEADLINE:

January 3rd 2027 11:59PM MDT

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